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What frames continuity and discontinuity of religion in families? A mixed-methods study of Finnish families in international comparison

Kati Tervo-Niemelä, Jenni Spännäri, and Laura Kallatsa

ABSTRACT
In this article, we analyze factors framing continuity and discontinuity of religion in families based on an integrative mixed methods approach. Using three-generation family interviews with Finnish families (62 interviewees in 17 families) and survey data collected in 5 countries (N = 8,404), we searched for themes that are meaningful for continuity and discontinuity related to religion in a family. We found four overarching themes: 1) religion as a shared vs. private matter, 2) safety and closeness vs. insecurity and distance, 3) flexibility vs. static attitudes, 4) structure and meaning. The article is linked to the Templeton-funded project "The Transmission of Religion across Generations: A Comparative International Study of Continuities and Discontinuities in Family Socialization", led by Christel Gärtner (University of Münster, Germany) and co-led by Kati Tervo-Niemelä (University of Eastern Finland, Finland).

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Religious transmission; family; generations; religiousness

Background

The Western world has seen a rapid rise in the proportion of persons with no religion, persons not believing or not belonging to any religious institutions, especially during the twenty-first century (see e.g. EVS 2017; Gärtner 2019; ISSP 2018; Niemelä 2007, 2015; Pew Research Center 2017; Pickel 2013; Voas and Chaves 2016; Voas and Doebler 2011; Woodhead 2017). Research using extensive international datasets has shown that key factors underlying these changes in religiosity are related to changes within generations: religiosity declines primarily between generations—not so much by the ageing of individuals—and the decline in religiosity is linked to people's lives before they reach adulthood. This implies that the key factors related to religious change are associated with family and family socialization (see e.g. Beyer 2018; Davie 2007; Gärtner 2018; Pollack 2008; Pollack, Müller, and Pickel 2012, Stolz et al. 2016; Voas and Doebler 2011; Voas and Watt 2014;

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Woodhead 2017.) This in turn means that, in order to identify factors explaining religious decline, we should primarily look at what happens to children and teenagers before they reach adulthood. Previous research suggests that, in an increasingly secular society, the conditions for successful transmission have become more complex; studies show that religious parents increasingly fail to pass on their religion to their offspring (Stolz et al. 2016, 11–50; Voas and Watt 2014, 17). For this reason, focusing on families and on the analysis of factors that are meaningful for religious continuity and discontinuity is of growing importance for religious communities.

The process of socialization refers to an interactive process in which parents and other socialization agents impart to children the knowledge, skills, and values they feel are meaningful in preparing them for adulthood (Bengtson, Putney, and Harris. 2013, 71–82). In the case of parents for whom religion is important, religion is a significant part of this process. The term 'religious socialization' is used to refer to the interactive process with which parents and other socialization agents influence individuals' beliefs and understanding (Sherkat 2003, 151). A substantial body of work shows that parents are the most important influence in shaping the religious and spiritual lives of children and youth; they are crucial for the transmission of worldviews, both religious and non-religious beliefs, practice, and behavior (see e.g. Schwab 1995; 2007; Beit-Hallahmi and Argyle 1997; Bengtson, Putney, and Harris 2013; Bengtson et al. 2009; Chatters and Taylor 2005; Grob, Morgenthaler, and Käppler 2009; Hood et al. 1996; Manning 2015; McIntosh and Spilka 1995; Pollack and Müller 2013; Schwab 1995, 2007; Smith and Adamzyk 2021). Yet, what contributes to successful intergenerational religious transmission? Why are some parents more successful than others in transmitting their religion?

Previous studies have identified multiple factors that are linked to successful or unsuccessful religious transmission. They include the following: the quality of the relationships and the atmosphere within the family (Bengtson, Putney, and Harris 2013, 71–98), warm and affirming relations between parents and children (Smith and Adamczyk 2021, 37–68), safe and secure attachment between children and parents (Granqvist 1998; Kirkpatrick 2005, 93–95), actual and perceived spousal agreement concerning religion and life more broadly (Bengtson, Putney, and Harris 2013, 88–89, 113–128; Grob, Morgenthaler, and Käppler 2009, 306–309). Furthermore, research suggests that parental influence is stronger for first-born children (Saroglou and Fiasse 2003; Chou and Elison 2014) and when parents are younger (Francis and Brown 1991). Research by Vern Bengtson, Norella Putney, and Susan Harris (2013, 58) further indicates that mainline Protestants are clearly the weakest in transmitting their religion to the next generation, whereas Evangelical Protestants, Jews, and Mormons appear to be the most successful. Furthermore, the study shows that, from the 1970s to 2005, the continuity of non-religion has strengthened while the continuity of most

religious traditions, especially mainline Protestantism and secondly Catholicism, has significantly weakened (Bengtson, Putney, and Harris 2013, 57–58). This is in line with studies which show that the clear decline in religiousness took first place in European countries where mainline Protestantism had formerly been a state religion. Catholic countries as well as the US and Canada were following this declining trend, but later (see e.g. Davie 2002; EVS 2017; ISSP 2018; Pew Research Center 2017, 2019; Inglehart 2021).

The longest and broadest study of families and religion thus far was conducted by Bengtson, Putney, and Harris (2013). They tied together the results related to families and religious transmission in a *theory of intergenerational religious momentum.* This theory states that the most crucial factors that impede or encourage intergenerational religious momentum are related to parental behavior: role modeling (what parents do in setting examples for religious practice and belief) and the quality of the parent–child relationship (intergenerational solidarity). A family's religious inheritance also plays a role as well as the parents' religious involvement and whether they are of the same religious faith. (Bengtson, Putney, and Harris 2013, 192–195) The grandparents' religious influences can also be meaningful, serving as both independent and joint agents in religious socialization (ibid, 99–112; Bengtson and Silverstein 2019). Influences from religious organizations, friends, and education are secondary to family influences, but are often also important for continuity in the religiousness of the family. Different contextual factors—influences from contemporary culture, historical events, and generational differences in religious expression—can also reinforce or detract from the probability of children following their parents' religion. (Bengtson, Putney, and Harris 2013, 192–195)

In this article, we analyze the factors related to continuity and discontinuity in intergenerational religious transmission in a European context—Finland—with a predominantly mainline Protestant context. Many studies have touched upon this issue over the years. However, changes in religiousness have been occurring rapidly during the twenty-first century, so that there is a need for up-to-date research on the topic. There may well be changed mechanisms in religious transmission. Furthermore, most of the previous studies, including the largest by Bengtson, Putney and Harris (2013), were conducted in the US, where the role of religion is in many ways different from that in Europe and, more importantly, from that in Finland. Together with its neighboring countries (the other Nordic countries and Estonia), Finland is one of the countries where religious socialization is given the least emphasis in Europe (EVS 2017). According to the European Values Study published in 2017, only 7% of Finns mentioned religion as one of the five most important things that children should be encouraged to engage with. Finland has also seen a rapid decline in religion during the twenty-first century (see e.g. Kääriäinen, Niemelä, and Ketola 2005; Salomäki et al. 2021).

Finland is still a predominantly Lutheran country, although the percentage of those not belonging to registered religious communities has increased from 12.7% in 2000 to 33.7% in 2023. At the same time, the percentage of those belonging to the Evangelical Lutheran Church has declined from 85.1% to 63.5% (Statistics Finland 2024). Church affiliation has declined particularly among young adults. In 2023, of those over 90 years old, 89% belonged to the Evangelical Lutheran Church. Among those in the age group 30–39, the corresponding percentage was 47% (Sohlberg and Ketola 2024, 46). Finland is thus an especially interesting context for examining religious continuity in a changing religious environment.

Materials and methods

Using a mixed methods approach based on three-generation family interviews and survey data, we investigate in this article what affects and frames the continuity and discontinuity of religiousness and non-religiousness in Finnish families. We also contextualize this investigation within international data to examine which of these framing factors are specifically Finnish and the extent to which this is the case. We aim to discover the key factors which are meaningful in the process in which religious or other convictions are—or are not—passed on from one generation to another in Finland. By using a mixed methods approach (Cohen, Manion, and Morrison 2018; Creswell 2010; Creswell and Plano Clark 2011) we aim to provide a more complete and comprehensive understanding of the factors underlying continuity and discontinuity related to religion in families. The foundation of the mixed methods approach is the idea that the world is best understood through a comprehensive perspective; therefore, we believe that combining multiple types of data and multiple methods in the analysis provides a better understanding of the factors underlying continuity and discontinuity than relying on a single approach alone (see Cohen, Manion, and Morrison 2018, 31–33).

Our data were collected within the international study "The Transmission of Religion across Generations: A Comparative International Study of Continuities and Discontinuities in Family Socialization" funded by the John Templeton Foundation (2019–2022), which covers five countries: Finland, Germany, Italy, Hungary, and Canada. In this study, Finland represents a country in which Protestant Christianity and especially the Lutheran Church have played a strong role. The research project was led by Christel Gärtner (University of Münster, Germany) and co-led by Kati Tervo-Niemelä (University of Eastern Finland, Finland), with co-leaders from three other participating countries: Peter Beyer (University of Ottawa), Roberta Ricucci (University of Turin, Italy), and Gergely Rosta (Pázmány Péter Catholic University, Budapest).

Within the study, we collected survey data and conducted in-depth biographical family interviews. The survey data were collected by telephone interviews at the turn of 2020–2021. The data collection was carried out in the five participating countries by NorStat, a European market research company specializing in data collection and analysis, with a total of 8,404 respondents, of whom 1,500 were Finnish. The sample is representative.

In addition to the quantitative data collection, we conducted three-generation family interviews. During the interviews, at least one representative of each generation was present: grandparents (referred in the article as 'G1 generation'), parents ('G2 generation'), and children aged at least 15 ('G3 generation'). The family interviews were thus primarily conducted as group interviews. We interviewed a total of 62 people in 17 families in Finland, with varying religious backgrounds. The interviewees included families and family members belonging to the Lutheran Church, the Eastern Orthodox Church, and various revival movements as well as families not belonging to any religious group. The aim was to find families from as diverse backgrounds as possible, both in cities and in the countryside.

At the beginning of the interviews, participants made a drawing in which they depicted the people who influenced their views and other things. The purpose of the use of a visual method (see e.g. Banks 2015) was to activate family members to reflect on the interview themes and to help them talk about a topic that some may have found difficult. The drawings were also referred to during several interviews, with the visualization helping both interviewees and interviewer to manage the potentially complex interpersonal networks in the families. The actual interview started with the same opening question for all the families:

> We are interested in how you have passed on values, beliefs and in general what is important to you, from one generation to the next and what has changed in the process over time. Can you tell us what it is like in your family?

The interviewer aimed at guiding the course of the interview and the topics emerging in it as little as possible and allowing families to talk of the themes that the family members themselves found meaningful in relation to the opening question. This worked differently in the various families: in some, the interviews proceeded on the basis of the family's own conversation, with the interviewer asking only a few specific questions, mainly toward the end of the interview. In other families, the interviewer guided the interview with more specific questions. For this purpose, the interviewers had a thematic interview framework, which was used when necessary. In addition to the interview, background information on the family's history was collected (including dates of birth, places of residence, and occupations of family members and previous generations as long as there was memory in the family, typically as far back as the grandparents' generation). The duration of

the interviews with the families varied between about two and four hours. The interviews were conducted in Finnish by the authors of this article, recorded, and transcribed. The interviewees were recruited via social media (especially Facebook), by contacting various stakeholders, and by snowball method. The authors also presented the study at several events and the researchers of the Finnish sub-project were interviewed in the media, which resulted in new informants.[1]

In this study, we used an integrative mixed methods design (see Creswell 2010; Creswell and Plano Clark 2011): by concurrent use of qualitative and quantitative methods we aimed at combining the descriptive richness of the information provided by family interviews with the precision in measurements afforded by the quantitative survey (Castro et al. 2010). The integrative mixed methods design was employed during the data collection. We started simultaneously with the first family interviews and the initial planning of the survey. With the knowledge we had gained from these family interviews, we continued preparing the quantitative survey instrument. After having finalized the survey instrument and collected the survey data, and after the initial analysis of the quantitative data, we used the knowledge gained from the first analyses of the quantitative study when recruiting further families for interviews.

We then started the initial analysis of both qualitative and quantitative data. The analysis of the latter included basic descriptive analysis and the comparison of different generations regarding religiosity and family religiousness and family influences. In the first phase of the analysis of the interview material, we listened and then read the material several times in order to create a general understanding of the themes the families were discussing when reflecting on the transmission of religion and values and generational changes.

In order to meet the aim of this article and to identify the main factors related to religious continuity and discontinuity, we began with a data-driven content analysis of the themes which were noted when families talked about the transfer of religious traditions, continuity or discontinuity. We categorized the themes found in the interview material into 28 themes. These included themes such as parental influence, church membership, image of God, relation to faith over the life course, confirmation, friends, other church activities, religious authorities, moving house, and death. We then compiled the material from each interview that was related to each of these 28 themes in a separate content analysis file (one for each interview), with a separate section for each interviewee in a given family. To support the analysis, a genogram describing the family history was made for each family. This allowed us to place factors related to historical contexts or to each person or to interpersonal relationships that were important for the family as a whole. We worked simultaneously with the 28 themes and the genogram in order to understand the broader context of each family, before looking specifically at the factors that produce religious

continuity or interruptions within each family. We reflected on the relation of all the 28 themes we had compiled during the qualitative content analysis to religious continuity and discontinuity in a family. From this material, we identified four meta-level themes that form the core of this article as well as its structure. We call these meta-themes. These are themes that emerged strongly as such in the interview material, but also themes that appeared as background factors when families were discussing issues related to the transmission of religion with their family members. Our analysis was strongly data-driven, meaning that we wanted specifically to identify the topics that derive from the data themselves. The four meta-themes we identified are as follows: religion as a shared vs. private matter, safety and closeness vs. insecurity and distance, flexibility vs. static attitudes, structure and meaning.

We returned to the quantitative material to investigate whether these themes emerged in the quantitative data and to explore the extent to which the survey data provide support for, complement or show inconsistencies in relation to what we found in the interview material, as this might prompt us to reconsider our qualitative material. We then revisited the analysis of the interview material with the knowledge gained from the analysis of the quantitative data in order to see whether there was anything we had overlooked in the previous analysis.

Results

Religion as a shared vs. private matter

The analysis of the interview material revealed that the question whether religion was an issue that was openly discussed and reflected upon in the family was one of the key factors for religious continuity. Families with a strong continuity also had a readiness for open discussion related not only to religion and faith but also to other deeper issues in life. These were issues like values in general or death and sorrow. The readiness or its lack for open discussion about religion and faith was not only reflected in the interviews (for example, in families talking about faith issues), but also present in the ways family members communicated with each other at a more general level in the interview (for example, the ease and openness with which they talked about religion and faith).

Interviews revealed different ‘talking cultures’ related to religion in families. At one extreme are families in which religion was openly discussed in a variety of everyday situations, including situations related to personal feelings and experiences. At the other extreme are families in which religion or other deep issues in life were not discussed at all. Some families talked about the deeper issues of life, but not about religion. Some families talked about

religion in terms of culture, politics, and other public affairs, but not at a personal level. Religion also appeared to be a source of conflict in families, which could also be a reason why they were silent about it.

It was evident that a family typically did not have a single communication culture, but several in the various 'branches' of the family. The interviews show that in practice each family consists of a number of family units and that all of them have their own stories and cultures. It is not only the culture of the family where the youngest family member is growing up that is meaningful, but also the stories and cultures of parents' and grandparents' families and other important current or former family members may play a role. This means that each family and its culture are the 'product' of multiple families. Religion was also an issue that was openly discussed with some family members, but not with others.

The quantitative data revealed that, compared to the four other countries in the study, the Finns are the ones who had least often talked about religion and faith, as well as things that were important to them in general, with their family members when they were teenagers. Of the five countries surveyed, the countries with the most open family interaction are Hungary, with regard to talking about important matters, and Italy, with regard to talking about religion, with Finland being at the other extreme in both respects. Only 27% and 16% of Finns had talked at least occasionally about faith and religion with their mothers and fathers, respectively, when they were teenagers. In Italy, the corresponding percentages are 47% and 32%.

However, the interviews suggest that there is a generational change taking place in Finnish families in relation to openness and talking with each other. In many families, the older generation tended to report little discussion about religion and faith or other worldview issues in their childhood homes, even when religion had been actively and regularly practiced. Table 1 shows the examples of families F2, F14, and F16, where the shift in the culture of speaking and not speaking was particularly pronounced.[2] While the oldest generation was not used to talking about faith and religion, their children

Table 1. A shift in the culture of speaking and not speaking.

	Grandparent	Parent	Youth
Family 2	"Very seldom do I talk [about religion]."	"Yes, I can sometimes talk about religious and spiritual issues."	"I have talked with my school-mates."
Family 14	"No, I have never talked."	"We do have different kinds of dinner-table discussions related to religion and other matters."	"I think we have talked and there have been arguments for and against. Sometimes it doesn't go so well and the discussion has not been so good and peaceful."
Family 16	"I have to say that it is almost a taboo. I have hardly ever discussed the matter."	"We have discussed it quite a bit."	"It is quite strongly present in daily life, talking and discussion and teaching in line with our values."

were much more open about such subjects and, for their grandchildren, such talk was commonplace. However, many members of the younger generation speak of religion in a rather general way, one possible reason being that religion is not very important for them at a personal level.

The survey data support the findings about the increased openness among the younger generation. For example, almost half (46%) of the 18–24-year-olds said that they regularly talked to their mothers about things that were important to them, compared to one in four (28%) of people aged 65–74. A similar difference can be seen in conversations with other family members and with friends. Among adolescents and young adults, only a very small proportion (2–4%) had never discussed important matters with friends in their youth, compared with one in four (24%) of those aged 75 and over.

The quantitative data show that communicating is important for continuity: the more discussions respondents had with their parent(s), the stronger the correlation between their own religiousness and their parents' religiousness during their childhood (measured by the question "How religious would you say your parents and grandparents were when you were a child?", with a response scale of 1–5, where 1 means "not religious at all " and 5 means "very religious"). For example, if a respondent never talked about religion or faith with their father, the correlation coefficient for their religiousness and that of their father is .16* in Finland and .23*** in all five countries in the study. If there was regular discussion, the correlation between respondent and father was 64*** in Finland and .60*** in all five countries. Talking about religion was typical in families with close relations, as closeness is the second meta-theme we found in the data. The correlation coefficient between talking about important issues with mother and closeness with mother in Finland was .43.*** (.47*** in all five countries), with closeness with father and talking with him .54*** (.53*** in the five countries).[3] Our findings are in line with those of the study by David Dollahite and Jennifer Thatcher (2008): open conversations between parents and children as well as close relationships within the family build positive experiences of talking about religion in families.

Safety and closeness vs. insecurity and distance

The second meta-theme we discovered in our analysis, framing continuity and discontinuity, was how much safety and closeness, as opposed to insecurity and distance, the interviewed family members experienced. Safety and closeness versus insecurity and distance are experienced widely in the lives of children and they are important at various levels. Safety and closeness are not only important in terms of parent–child relationships, but also in relation to religion more broadly: how religious institutions are present in the family and in the lives of children and what the nature and expression of religion

and spirituality are in the family in terms of safety and closeness. Our findings regarding these three levels (safety and closeness in the family, in religious communities, and in one's own spiritual life) are presented in Table 2.

The families with the strongest continuity were families with safety and closeness at different levels. In families, factors that create safety and closeness appear, for example, when parents share their values with their children, but at the same time do not force them to hold similar beliefs so that the children have the possibility to choose their own worldviews. There are no conflicts in words and deeds in the families with a safe atmosphere, whereas discrepancy in words and deeds creates insecurity and emotional loneliness. This discrepancy was, for example, strongly evident in a family in which the G1 generation mother (grandmother) occasionally had to hide all the knives in the house from her very religious spouse so that he could not harm himself or anybody else. This created an atmosphere that was characterized by insecurity; although religion was strongly present in the family and the father wanted to pass it on to the next generation, the second-generation family member would have ended up espousing atheism, had he not met his future wife. She had been raised in a strongly religious home, but in a safe and secure family atmosphere. The grandmother, on the other hand, ended up leaving the church, but kept her faith, thanks to her own safe family background.

Safety and closeness are also important in relation to religious communities. Insecurity and distance in religious communities appear, for example, in conjunction with members being forced to believe or being intimidated with threats of hell and the end of the world. This kind of intimidation was

Table 2. Safety and closeness versus insecurity and distance in the continuity stories of families: three levels.

	Safety and closeness	Insecurity and distance
In the family	Warm and open atmosphere Values are present, but with freedom to choose Coherence in words and deeds Consistency	Emotional coldness Insecurity Contradiction of words and deeds Unclear choices and inconsistencies Intimidation Unprocessed (often over generational) traumas
In religious communities	Open and safe atmosphere A safe and stable community to return to, even if distant Repetitive, safe rituals	Intimidation by hell; condemnation and coercion Contradictory teaching Withdrawal is harshly treated Pressure for faith settlement Apocalypse sermons Strict rules
Essence of faith	Personal, safe faith A warm image of God Gentle religiosity	Harsh image of God External faith Uncertain image of God The strong faith of others vs. their own insecurities

mostly mentioned by G1 generation family members; it was never mentioned as something positive or as strengthening faith, but always as something negative or ridiculous or as creating distance from faith. Younger family members hardly raised such matters, which indicates changes in the teaching styles in religious communities. Furthermore, when it comes to the essence of faith, warm and gentle religiosity and a positive image of God support continuity, whereas an uncertain relation to God as well as a feeling of disconnectedness undermines continuity. Additionally, the comparison to 'true believers' makes people feel that they are inadequate believers.

The quantitative data also show clearly that closeness between parents and children supports religious continuity. The correlation coefficient for a respondent's and their mother's religiousness (as evaluated by the respondent) was only .14 in Finland and .20*** in all five countries when the relationship was judged as "not close at all". If the relationship with mother was extremely close, the correlation coefficients were .50*** (Finland) and .54*** (all five countries). The correlation coefficient for a respondent's and their father's religiousness was not significant (.02) for father and respondent in Finland and .21*** in all five countries when the relationship was judged as "not close at all". If the relationship with father was close, the correlation coefficient was .56*** (both in Finland and in the five countries).

Flexibility vs. static attitudes

The third meta-theme in the interview material is flexibility versus static attitudes. This theme was present in the interview material in several different areas which are shown in Table 3. They include intergenerational religion, faith and beliefs, belonging to a religious community, religious education, religion in the life cycle, and religious communities and their

Table 3. Flexibility and static attitudes at different levels.

	Flexibility	Static attitudes
Religion between generations	Different ways to believe and practice religion are tolerated.	The next generation is expected to believe and practice religion in the same way as the previous ones.
Beliefs	Personal beliefs can be questioned and discussed.	There is only one way to believe/behave/belong. No questioning is accepted.
Belonging	Changes and differences in belonging are accepted.	Belonging is unbreakable.
Religious education	Encouragement, support and willingness to offer different ways to understand the world.	Strictness in upbringing and 'preacher style'.
Religion and life course	Changes in religion over a lifetime are seen as natural.	Stability over the lifetime. Religion is expected to remain the same.
Religious organizations	Should change and be flexible.	Should maintain tradition and stay as they are.

activities. In each of these areas, the interview material revealed both flexible and dynamic attitudes and rigid and static ones. In families in which religious continuity appeared to be strongest, there was clear flexibility, for example, in relation to membership and participation in religious communities.

By contrast, breaks in religiosity were often linked to static or rigid beliefs and practices, for example, in religious education. The following interviewee (male, G3 generation member) pondered:

> Could it be, like grandma said, that the rupture was caused by the fact that they were forced to sit in the church? That they didn't want to take it forward to us. We never had that; we were never forced. And that has made the road (to being religious) easy, at least for me. (Personal interview, 3 August 2020)[4]

However, static beliefs and practices did not necessarily lead to a break in continuity, but could also contribute to creating continuity and the structures described in the next section.

In the interview material, flexibility was manifested as a positive attitude toward the younger generation living and practicing their religiosity differently from the earlier generations. Conversely, a rigid attitude manifested in expecting the next generation to believe and practice in the same way as their predecessors. Similarly, a previous study has shown that not forcing faith and allowing exploration both support religious continuity in families and children's agency (Barrow, Dollahite, and Marks 2021). In relation to faith and beliefs, flexibility and dynamism were reflected in the personal nature of faith and the willingness to discuss faith openly, also when questioned and challenged. Rigidity and static attitudes in relation to faith and beliefs, on the other hand, appeared as emphasis on only one correct belief and a negative attitude toward discussing it. Flexibility and dynamism also implied being open to changes in religiosity over the course of one's life. At different stages of life, individuals may perceive different communities as better suited to their own religious needs and this mobility was seen positively in families where this was the case (for further details on the role of religious communities in family transmission, see Tervo-Niemelä 2021). The quantitative data show that such changes in religiosity often occur over a person's lifetime. As many as about half of the respondents reported being either more or less religious at the time of our data collection than they had been as children. This means that preserving the sense of belonging in the midst of changes in life, in relation to the family or the religious community, thus calls for greater flexibility and dynamic attitudes toward religion. The interview data show that, if people are faced with accepting, flexible, and tolerant attitudes when distancing themselves from their faith, there is a greater likelihood of them returning, whereas the likelihood of this is very low when they are treated with no tolerance or flexibility.

Structure and meaning

The fourth meta-theme is called structure and meaning. By 'structure' we refer to formal and permanent structures of religion, whereas 'meaning' refers to experiences, emotions, and meaningfulness at a personal level. In our interview data, structure consists of the institutional and stable aspects of religion. These aspects are, for example: belonging to religious communities, habits, rules, traditions and rituals in homes, religious education in schools and churches, and regular participation in different religious activities. Religious authorities and role models may also serve as important stable structures. In addition to structures, continuity requires personal experiences and emotions. These are strongly embodied. The interviews show that they are very meaningful for continuity for all the generations. The most general experiences in our interviews were conversion experiences, singing, practicing silence, experiences at confirmation camp, and supernatural experiences.

Our data show that transmission of religion needs both stable structures and embodied aspects, experiences and emotions, as this interviewee (male, G2 generation member) described:

> I've always had a constant need to have that [religious] community in my life. Although, of course, my belief has become personal. But a single log does not burn for very long, it needs the connection with others. (Personal interview, 19 October 2020)

Our interview material indicates that, if religion is only about structures, religiosity appears as cultural Christianity or 'belonging without believing', as Nordic religiosity is often described (see e.g. Niemelä 2015), or regarding religion as following strict rules. On the other hand, if religion exists only as embodied expression without structure, religion is only about individual choice and experience and this weakens its continuity.

The quantitative data show that structures that are supporting continuity of religion in Finland are especially the high (although declining) church membership rate, the strong role of religious education in churches (especially Lutheran confirmation), and Religious Education (RE) at school. As many as 93% of Finnish respondents had attended RE at school, 68% said that they had received religious education from a religious institution, and 93% were confirmed in the Evangelical Lutheran Church of Finland. The percentage of church confirmation (typically at the age of 15) has remained high: 90% in 2000 and still as high as 73% in 2023 (Church Membership Statistics 2023). When it comes to the home, clear religious upbringing takes place less than in most of the other countries in our data: 43% said their mothers had brought them up to be religious, 22% said their fathers had. Of the different religious family traditions, almost all the forms

of religious activity that were asked about in the survey were rarer in Finland than in the other countries. Evening prayer was the only form of activity which has traditionally had a strong role. Of all the respondents, 36% had had regular evening prayer at home. However, this activity is also clearly in decline.

Discussion

In this article, we used an integrative mixed methods approach based on three-generation family interviews and survey data to identify the key factors framing religious continuity and discontinuity in Finnish families. Finland is a country where mainline Protestantism, more specifically Lutheranism, has traditionally had a strong role. Previous studies show that religiosity has been declining especially in this context, which makes Finland a particularly interesting country in which to study these issues. When searching for factors framing continuity and discontinuity, we identified four meta-themes: 1) religion as a shared vs. private matter, 2) safety and closeness vs. insecurity and distance, 3) flexibility vs. static attitudes, 4) structure and meaning.

The role of these four meta-themes in supporting the continuity of religion in the family can be summarized as follows: religion is discussed openly in a family. Religion is linked to closeness and safety at multiple levels: within family relationships, in religious communities, and the substance of faith. Religion is seen as flexible and dynamic, both between generations, over the lifetime of individuals and in religious education, and in relation to faith itself, membership of a community and its activities. It is also important that religion includes both the formal and permanent structures and embodied experiences, emotions, and meaningfulness at a personal level.

The results on the importance of safety and closeness in religious transmission confirm the findings of previous studies concerning the importance of the quality of family relationships, secure attachment, and warm and close intra-family relationships in the transmission of faith. The importance of these in families has been pointed out in numerous studies (see e.g. Dollahite and Thatcher 2008; Bengtson, Putney, and Harris 2013; Barrow, Dollahite, and Marks 2021). However, our results show that closeness and safety are not only important at the family level, but also more broadly in relation to religious institutions and the substance of faith. Adding to earlier research, our study also highlights flexibility as a key theme for continuity. Flexible attitudes and practices not only toward family members and their individual choices, but also toward religion as well as toward and by religious organizations in general, appear to be significant factors building continuity in the families. Distance, as well as harshness, judgmentalism, and static attitudes, tend to turn people away from religion. For religious education, be it at home or in religious or other communities,

such attitudes should thus be avoided. Earlier studies have shown that such themes tend to emerge as reasons for leaving the church (see e.g. Niemelä 2015, 2007).

The results show that one of the few strong family traditions and supporting structures for religiousness in Finnish families has been the evening prayer. However, its role has declined as well. This may have longstanding consequences not only for religion but also for family togetherness. As Joe Chelladurai, David Dollahite, and Loren Marks (2018) show, family prayer provides unique and salient opportunities for family togetherness and is associated with important relational processes in families.

The importance of talking about faith and religion at home is a theme which has often been neglected in studies related to religious transmission, especially in those based on quantitative data. Our results show that Finns talk less in families, when it comes to both religion and other important issues, than people from the other countries studied. This result is in line with previous studies on the silence of Finns and the fact that religion is regarded as a private matter (Lehtonen and Sajavaara 1985; Hofstede 1994). One of the few studies paying clear attention to the importance of talking within families is a recent study by Christian Smith and Amy Adamczyk (2021). They reported that parents talking with their children was even more strongly associated with the importance of religion later in young adulthood than the importance of parents' faith or more frequent service attendance (Smith and Adamczyk 2021, 38–40, 53–54). Our results support these findings and highlight the importance of family members talking to each other. Adding to earlier research on the subject (e.g. Bengtson, Putney, and Harris 2013; Smith and Adamczyk 2021), our study also emphasizes the importance of relations more broadly for religious continuity. Continuity is created through warm and meaningful relations within the family and within religious groups, but also in relation to the divine—in a warm and safe atmosphere, through sharing, giving space, and providing chances for meaningfulness and personal experiences.

However, our results show that the relations between family members were perceived as somewhat more distant in Finland than in the other countries surveyed. The weak sense of closeness between members in Finnish families and the longstanding culture of not talking with one another raise the question whether these have been contributing factors to the decline in religious continuity in Finland in recent decades. Nonetheless, our analysis shows that this culture of silence seems to be breaking down: younger people are more open and talkative. Young people talk more openly about issues important to them than previous generations, both with their parents and their grandparents. For many, talking about religion is also easier than for older generations. This offers new horizons for religious upbringing and education.

This study has some limitations. The data were collected in predominantly Christian, industrialized countries and, even there, the cross-country analysis of the qualitative material is only starting. In this article, the analysis of the qualitative data is limited to the data collected in Finland. However, in conclusion, our findings add novel and significant contributions, both methodologically and thematically, to the study of continuities and discontinuities of religion and religious education.

Note

1. Ethics clearance from the relevant university was not required for this study.
2. We refer to the interviews by the letter F which means 'family' and a number which is the running number used in the data analysis.
3. Closeness was measured by the question "How close did you feel to [the following family members] when you were a child? The scale ranges from 1 to 5, where 1 represents "not close at all" and 5 represents "extremely close".
4. All the quotes from the interviews are translated from Finnish into English by the authors.

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